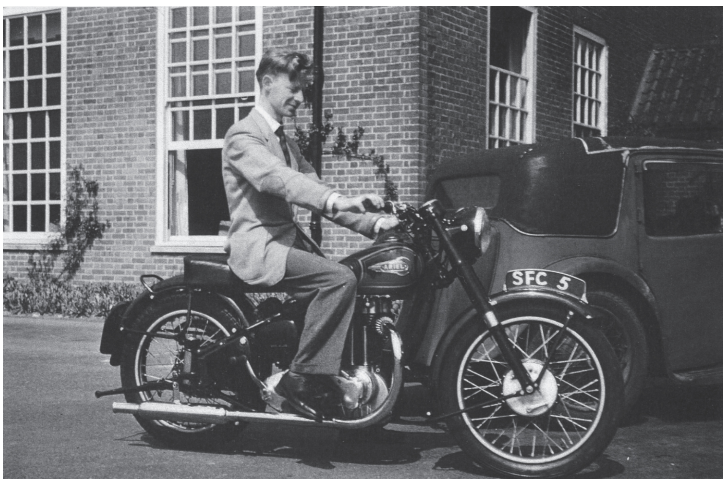


Figure 7.1. John Bell in Harwell, c. 1952.

Bell was shocked by the chilly reception that Bohm's ideas received. "For twenty-five years people were saying that [alternatives to Copenhagen] were impossible. After Bohm did it, some of the same people said that now it was trivial. They did a fantastic somersault." After reading Bohm's papers, Bell immediately recognized that von Neumann's proof must be wrong, but it still wasn't available in English. So he found a colleague at Harwell who spoke German, Franz Mandl. "Franz… told me something of what von Neumann was saying," Bell recalled later. "I already felt that I saw what von Neumann's unreasonable axiom was."

But von Neumann's proof wasn't published in English for another three years, and by the time it was, Bell had started entirely different work for his PhD. When Bell arrived at graduate school, his PhD advisor, Rudolf Peierls, asked him to give a talk on what he'd been working on lately. Bell said he could talk about either accelerator physics or interpretations of quantum physics. Peierls told him he would much prefer Bell give his talk about accelerators. Bell complied, and for the next few years he stayed away from questions about the meaning of quantum physics.

Several years later, Bell met Bohr himself at CERN (the European Laboratory for Particle Physics, best known today as the home of the Large Hadron Collider), in Geneva, Switzerland. The Bells had just started working there, and Bohr was among the many luminaries who arrived for the inauguration of the then-new research center. Bell ran into Bohr in an elevator and wasn't sure how to talk to the living legend. "I didn't have the